

Primary Source Reading: Plato's *Theaetetus* — The Self-Refutation of Protagoras

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.04 — Is Morality Just Our Custom? Translated by Benjamin Jowett

Before you read: Theaetetus has just proposed that knowledge is simply perception. Socrates connects this to a famous doctrine of the Sophist Protagoras. As you read, first find the doctrine stated plainly, then follow Socrates as he turns the doctrine back on itself. This second passage is the one the lesson asks you to paraphrase.

The Doctrine Stated

SOCRATES: Well, you have delivered yourself of a very important doctrine about knowledge; it is indeed the opinion of Protagoras, who has another way of expressing it. Man, he says, is the measure of all things, of the existence of things that are, and of the non-existence of things that are not... Does he not say that things are to you such as they appear to you, and to me such as they appear to me, and that you and I are men?

THEAETETUS: Yes, he says so.

Turning the Doctrine Against Itself

SOCRATES: And how about Protagoras himself? If neither he nor the multitude thought, as indeed they do not think, that man is the measure of all things, must it not follow that the truth of which Protagoras wrote would be true to no one? But if you suppose that he himself thought this, and that the multitude does not agree with him, you must begin by allowing that in whatever proportion the many are more than one, in that proportion his truth is more untrue than true.

THEODORUS: That would follow if the truth is supposed to vary with individual opinion.

SOCRATES: And the best of the joke is, that he acknowledges the truth of their opinion who believe his own opinion to be false; for he admits that the opinions of all men are true.

THEODORUS: Certainly.

SOCRATES: And does he not allow that his own opinion is false, if he admits that the opinion of those who think him false is true?

THEODORUS: Of course.

SOCRATES: Then all mankind, beginning with Protagoras, will contend, or rather, I should say that he will allow, when he concedes that his adversary has a true opinion

— Protagoras, I say, will himself allow that neither a dog nor any ordinary man is the measure of anything which he has not learned — am I not right?

THEODORUS: Yes.

SOCRATES: And the truth of Protagoras being doubted by all, will be true neither to himself to any one else?

THEODORUS: I think, Socrates, that we are running my old friend too hard.

After you read: This is the passage the lesson asks you to paraphrase. Before you write your two or three sentences, notice exactly what Socrates does: he does not argue that Protagoras is wrong about any particular fact. He shows that the doctrine, applied to itself, cannot be consistently held at all — if “every opinion is true” is itself just one more opinion, then the opinion that Protagoras is wrong must be just as true as Protagoras’s own view. State the argument in your own words before moving on to the essay assignment.